which is a longish sedimentary sandstone marker pinpointing what was believed to be the exact place of birth.[25] There would in Ashoka's day also have been a large brick platform near it. Did Ashoka think it too modest as a shrine given the Buddha's stature? Or was the emperor inscribing his presence in the place of his preceptor's birth as his most powerful patron? This question is relevant because Ashoka did not merely pay obeisance. He erected a pillar and erected a much larger temple-like edifice over the birthplace. The magnificent monolithic pillar was hewn out of sandstone. While only part of it has survived (nearly four metres below the ground and a little more than five metres above), when it was set up the pillar was likely to have been several metres taller, with an inverted lotus capital and an animal image on top. The remnants of the abacus and bell capital have survived, but not the crowning animal. Xuanzang, much impressed in the seventh century, reports seeing the column topped by a stone horse.

Many similar pillars were fashioned during Ashoka's reign, all monolithic and freestanding, placed on base-slabs below ground. Like the Barabar caves, their quality speaks highly of the technical expertise involved:

> The pillars have a certain air of perfection; they are admirably polished, their tapering gives them elegance, their proportions are well-balanced. The threefold capitals have been designed and produced with a quality never to be reached again by later copyists. It requires some skill and experience to produce such pieces of art; another sort of experience is needed to transport them from the quarry to their place of erection, and it requires still further expertise to erect the pillars weighing from 8.6 (Lumbini) to 51 (Vesali) tons and finally to top them with capitals weighing a further two tons.[26]

Pillars and poles were the kind of paraphernalia constructed at festivals and religious places. However, it is unlikely that those erected in times before Ashoka were remotely like his. This combination of a tapering polished monolith topped with animals and other sacred symbols was an Ashokan innovation.[27] The pillars were fashioned out of Chunar sandstone, a high